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The Indian Personal Trainer Business Playbook

Get clients. Price right. Keep them past day 90.

₹16,200 cr	0.8%	~80%	~60%
India fitness market, CY24	population penetration	of new trainers quit in 2 yrs	of clients drop by day 90

Get clients. Price right. Keep them past day 90.

Market numbers · cost per session · three-tier offer · a 30-day sprint
the 90-day lifecycle · 40 message templates · forms · GST, TDS & income tax

67 pages · every figure dated and sourced · October 2026

Read this first

This is not a workout book. There are a thousand free workout plans on the internet and you already know how to coach. This playbook is about the part of the job that actually decides whether you are still training clients in 2029: getting them, pricing them properly, keeping them past the point where most Indian clients quietly disappear, and staying out of tax trouble while you do it.

Every number in here was checked against a named source in October 2026 and is dated on the page where it appears. Where something is an estimate rather than a measurement, it says so. Where a rule might have changed by the time you read this, it tells you exactly what to confirm and where.

> **The one promise**
> If you do only two things in this book — build the three-tier offer in Part 2 and run the 90-day touchpoint map in Part 4 — you will earn more from the clients you already have, without finding a single new one. Everything else is upside.

How to use it

- **If you have no clients yet:** read Part 1, then do Part 2 (pricing), then run the 30-day sprint in Part 3. Do not read the rest until you have signed your first client this month.
- **If you have 3-8 clients and feel stuck:** go straight to Part 4. Your problem is almost certainly retention and re-pricing, not lead generation.
- **If you are a gym floor trainer going independent:** read Part 2 and Part 7 before you take a single payment. The pricing and tax decisions you make in week one follow you for years.
- **If you run a small studio or train other trainers:** Parts 4, 6 and 9 are your operations manual. Photocopy the forms.

Written for independent trainers, freelance coaches, home and park trainers, and small studio owners in India. Prices are in rupees. Nothing here is medical, legal or tax advice for your specific situation — Part 6 sets out exactly where a trainer's scope ends, and Part 7 tells you which decisions to take to a CA.

Contents

Part 1	**The market you are actually in**	5
	1.1 The numbers, dated	6
	1.2 Why 80% quit inside two years	6
	1.3 The silent churn curve	7
	1.4 Where your next ten clients come from	8
Part 2	**Your money maths**	10
	2.1 What one session really costs you	11
	2.2 Break-even at three price points	12
	2.3 The three-tier offer	12
	2.4 What to charge in 2026-27	13
	2.5 The capacity ceiling and the income table	14
	2.6 Packages, advances and payment terms	15
	2.7 The four discount rules	16
Part 3	**Client acquisition**	18
	3.1 Why November to February is your season	19
	3.2 The 30-day acquisition sprint	19
	3.3 Google Business Profile in one afternoon	21
	3.4 The twelve-post Instagram grid	22
	3.5 WhatsApp: status, broadcast and the 24-hour rule	22
	3.6 The referral engine	23
	3.7 Offline: societies, parks and corporates	23
	3.8 The first reply: five enquiry scripts	24
	3.9 The 20-minute consultation that closes	25
Part 4	**The 90-day lifecycle**	27
	4.1 The touchpoint map	28
	4.2 Week zero: the first 48 hours	28
	4.3 Day 7, 14 and 30 check-ins	29
	4.4 The measurement ritual	30
	4.5 Day 45: the plateau conversation	30
	4.6 Day 60: the renewal close	31
	4.7 Five churn saves	31
	4.8 Why one long client beats three short ones	32
Part 5	**40 message templates**	34
Part 6	**The paperwork pack**	39

Part 7	**GST, TDS and income tax**	50
Part 8	**AI prompts and the tool stack**	56
Part 9	**Worksheets**	61
Part 10	**Your first 30 days**	65
	Sources and verification log	67

Page numbers refer to this PDF. Part dividers are counted.

PART 1

The market you are actually in

Before you change a single price, know the size of the room you are standing in.

1

1.1 The numbers, dated

India's fitness market was worth about ₹16,200 crore in calendar year 2024, across roughly 46,500 facilities and 12.3 million members. That is a membership penetration of about 0.8% of the population — one of the lowest in the world, against a target demographic of roughly 956 million people aged 18 to 62. The same Deloitte-HFA India Fitness Report 2025 projects the market at ₹37,700 crore by 2030, with 65,500 facilities and 23.2 million members.

Metric	2024	2030 (projected)	Growth
Market size	₹16,200 crore	₹37,700 crore	~15% CAGR
Fitness facilities	46,500	65,500	~6% CAGR
Members	12.3 million	23.2 million	~11% CAGR
Penetration	0.8%	1.7%	more than double
Boutique formats	fastest-growing segment	18.8% CAGR to 2030	—

Read those numbers the way an operator reads them, not the way a news article reads them. Facility count grows at 6% a year while members grow at 11% and revenue at 15%. That gap is the whole story: the money is not coming from more gyms, it is coming from more revenue per member — which means personal training, small-group coaching and premium formats. The Deloitte-HFA report says exactly that, and adds that the top ten cities generate about 56% of market revenue from just 31% of facilities.

For you the practical reading is this: the demand is real and growing, it is concentrated in ten cities, and it is shifting toward the coached, premium, small-format end of the market. That is your end.

How many trainers are you competing with?

An estimated 60,000 to 80,000 Indians work as independent personal trainers — solo operators running a business of one from a phone rather than as salaried gym staff. Only about 24,000 to 26,000 are visible on listing platforms after de-duplication, which means the majority are invisible: they run entirely on WhatsApp and word of mouth. That figure is a triangulated estimate, not a census, and the source labels it as such. Treat it as the right order of magnitude, not a precise count.

1.2 Why 80% quit inside two years

An estimated 80% of new personal trainers in India quit within two years, and the widely-cited reason is business-management pressure, not gaps in fitness knowledge. Sit with that for a second. The people leaving are not leaving because they cannot program a squat. They are leaving because the phone went quiet in month four, because they charged ₹500 a session and trained eleven clients a week, because a client stopped replying after three weeks and they never asked why.

There are exactly three ways this business fails, and they are all arithmetic:

1. **You priced below your cost.** A ₹600 session that takes 45 minutes of training plus 20 minutes of travel, 10 minutes of WhatsApp and a share of your rent is not a ₹600 session. Most trainers never do this sum, so they cannot tell whether a full diary is profit or a slow loss.
2. **You had no second sale.** One client, one package, one goodbye. Without a renewal conversation there is no business, only a sequence of first sales, each one costing five to ten times more to win than a renewal.
3. **You had no pipeline.** All your clients arrived in one burst from one gym, one friend group or one Instagram reel. When that source dried up, the diary emptied in six weeks.

The five-minute self-diagnostic

Score yourself honestly. Any row where you answer 'no' is the chapter you should read next.

Question	Yes	No	Go to
Do you know your cost per session, including travel and unpaid admin time?	☐	☐	2.1
Do you have three offers at three prices, or only one rate?	☐	☐	2.3
Did you raise any price in the last twelve months?	☐	☐	2.4
Can you name the source of your last five clients?	☐	☐	1.4
Do you contact every client at day 7, 14 and 30 without being asked?	☐	☐	4.3
Do you ask for a renewal before the last session, not after?	☐	☐	4.6
Do you have a written agreement and a health screen for every client?	☐	☐	Part 6
Do you issue a receipt or invoice for every payment?	☐	☐	7.4
Do you know whether you need GST registration this year?	☐	☐	7.1

1.3 The silent churn curve

About 60% of a trainer's clients drop off within 90 days, and typical monthly retention sits around 70-75%. Almost none of them tell you. They do not cancel; they reschedule twice, then stop replying, then you see them in the park with someone else six weeks later. This is silent churn, and it is the single largest leak in an independent trainer's income.

Silent churn is not random. It clusters in three windows, and each has a different cause and a different fix.

Window	What is happening	What it looks like	The fix
Days 10-21	Novelty has worn off, the first soreness has passed, results are not visible yet	One missed session, then two	Day 7 and day 14 check-ins; show a number moving
Days 30-45	The first real plateau; the scale stops moving or work gets busy	Asks to 'pause for a bit'	Day 30 measurement ritual; day 45 plateau conversation
Days 60-90	Package is nearly used up and there is no next step	Goes quiet at session 9 of 12	Renewal close at day 60, before the last session

The fix is not more motivation. Motivation is what got them to sign; it is not what keeps them. What keeps them is a schedule they did not have to think about, a number they can see moving, and a coach who noticed they were missing before they had to explain it.

> **The 60% is your opportunity**
> If 60% of clients leave inside 90 days, then the average trainer is re-selling the same client three times over. The trainer who holds a client for twelve months does not need a bigger pipeline — they need the same pipeline, kept. Part 4 is the whole system.

1.4 Where your next ten clients come from

Most trainers chase the channel with the most noise — Instagram — and neglect the one with the best conversion — the client standing in front of them. Here is the realistic ranking for an independent trainer in an Indian metro or tier-2 city, with honest effort and conversion notes.

Channel	Effort	Typical close rate	Cost	Best for
Referral from an existing client	Very low	Highest of any channel	₹0	Clients 5 onwards
Your own client's family / colleague	Very low	High	₹0	Filling a cancelled slot
Google Business Profile + reviews	One afternoon, then 10 min/week	Medium-high (high intent)	₹0	People searching 'personal trainer near me'
Society / apartment gym and park presence	Medium, in person	Medium-high	₹0	Home and park trainers
Instagram (reels of real clients)	High and continuous	Low per view, decent per DM	₹0-500/mo	Building a name, not a week
Paid ads	High (money + skill)	Low unless tightly targeted	₹5,000+/mo	Only after you convert well organically
Gym floor referrals / revenue share	Low	Medium	20-40% split	Fast start, thin margin
Marketplace apps and listing sites	Low	Low-medium, price-sensitive	Commission or lead fee	Volume, not margin

The rule that follows from this table: before you spend a rupee on ads or an hour a day on reels, make the free channels excellent. A trainer with 40 genuine Google reviews and a referral habit will out-earn a trainer with 8,000 followers and no system, every month of the year.

End of Part 1 — what to do now

You now know the size of the market, why most trainers leave it, and where your next ten clients will come from. The next part is the arithmetic that decides whether those clients make you a living.

☐ Write down the three ways this business fails and tick the one that describes you.
☐ Name the source of your last five clients. If you cannot, that is the finding.
☐ Note the two channels from 1.4 you will actually use this month — not the ones you like.

PART 1

Your money maths

The five sums that separate a trainer with a business from a trainer with a busy week.

1

2.1 What one session really costs you

Almost every underpriced trainer made the same mistake: they priced the session, not the hour. A session is not 45 minutes. It is 45 minutes of training, the travel on either side, the ten minutes of WhatsApp before and after, the program you wrote on Sunday, and a share of everything you pay whether you train anyone or not.

Here is the worksheet with a worked example. Ravi trains clients at their homes in Indore. Fill your own numbers in the blank column.

Line	How to work it out	Ravi's numbers	Yours
1. Monthly fixed costs	Rent/room, phone, insurance, subscriptions, certification amortised, transport pass	₹9,000	
2. Working days a month	Days you are actually willing to train	24	
3. Fixed cost per working day	Line 1 ÷ line 2	₹375	
4. Sessions per working day	Realistic, including travel	5	
5. Fixed cost per session	Line 3 ÷ line 4	₹75	
6. Travel per session	Round trip, actual cost	₹80	
7. Unpaid time per session	Travel + prep + messages, in minutes	50 min	
8. Your target monthly income	What you need to take home	₹45,000	
9. Sessions a month available	Line 2 × line 4	120	
10. Income needed per session	Line 8 ÷ line 9	₹375	
11. Minimum price per session	Line 5 + 6 + 10	₹530	
12. Add tax and buffer (15%)	Line 11 × 1.15	₹610	

Ravi was charging ₹500 a session. His true floor was ₹610. He was not running a business; he was paying ₹110 for the privilege of coaching people. Two changes fixed it without losing a client: he moved three home clients to a nearby park (travel ₹80 to ₹0) and moved new enquiries to a ₹650 park rate.

The three levers

Your price is only one of three. The others are travel (can you cluster clients in one area or one time block?) and unpaid time (can a template, a form or an AI draft cut the 50 minutes to 15?). Pulling the travel and admin levers is almost always easier than raising the price — and it is the difference between five sessions a day being exhausting and being comfortable.

2.2 Break-even at three price points

Once you know your floor, the next question is how many sessions a month you must sell to cover costs. The maths below uses a trainer with ₹18,000 of monthly fixed costs (a small rented training space, phone, insurance, software) and ₹60 of travel per session. Session counts are rounded up, because you cannot sell part of a session.

At this session rate	Contribution per session	Sessions to break even	Sessions for ₹40,000 take-home	Sessions for ₹75,000
₹500	₹440	41	132	212
₹750	₹690	27	85	135
₹1,000	₹940	20	62	99
₹1,500	₹1,440	13	41	65
₹2,000	₹1,940	10	30	48

Look at the last two rows. At ₹2,000 a session you need 30 sessions a month to take home ₹40,000 — about seven a week. At ₹500 you need 132 sessions, which is 30 a week, which is not a business, it is a queue. The Deloitte-HFA data and independent-trainer surveys put the typical metro session rate at ₹500 to ₹2,500, so both ends of this table are real prices being charged in the same city on the same day.

The lesson is not 'charge ₹2,000'. It is that the number of sessions you can physically deliver in a week is capped — realistically 25 to 35 for a mobile trainer, because travel eats the rest — and the only way to raise income inside that cap is price and format. Which is what Part 2.3 is for.

2.3 The three-tier offer

One rate is a trap. A single price forces every buyer into a yes-or-no decision, and the answer is usually no. Three tiers change the question from 'is this worth ₹8,000?' to 'which of these three do I want?' — and in every pricing study ever run on the subject, the middle tier wins.

Build your tiers on **contact hours and accountability**, not on 'more of the same'. The difference between tier two and tier three must be something a client can feel in week one.

	Tier 1 — Starter	Tier 2 — Transform	Tier 3 — Elite
Format	8 sessions, 4 weeks	24 sessions, 12 weeks	36 sessions, 12 weeks + nutrition check-ins
Sessions a week	2	2	3
Program	One written 4-week plan	Three progressive blocks	Three blocks + weekly adjustment
Check-ins	One WhatsApp check	Weekly check-in + monthly measurement	Twice-weekly check-in + fortnightly measurement
WhatsApp support	Replies within 24h	Replies within 12h	Replies within 4h, 6 days a week
Included	Form videos, habit sheet	Everything in Starter + travel within 5 km	Everything in Transform + 2 grocery-shop calls
Indicative price	₹6,000	₹16,000	₹26,000
Per-session equivalent	₹750	₹667	₹722
Why it exists	Low-risk first yes	The one you want them to buy	Anchors the middle and serves the serious

Notice the per-session equivalents. Tier 2 is the cheapest per session, which is exactly the story you tell: 'the twelve-week package is the best value because the results need twelve weeks'. Tier 3 costs more per session than tier 2 but delivers more contact — and its real job is to make tier 2 look sensible. That is not manipulation; it is honesty about what a three-times-a-week relationship costs you in hours.

> **Never sell a single session**
> A one-off session teaches a client that your service is a commodity you can buy on any Tuesday. Sell blocks. If someone insists on trying you first, make it a paid two-session 'starter' at full rate — free trials attract the clients who were never going to pay.

Adjusting the tiers to your market

These prices suit a tier-2 city trainer working at homes and parks. In Delhi NCR, Mumbai or Bengaluru, multiply the middle tier by 1.5 to 2 if you have proof — a full diary, real transformations, reviews. In a small town, keep tier 1 where it is, keep tier 2 within 20% of it, and cut what you deliver rather than what you charge: 20 sessions instead of 24, monthly measurement instead of fortnightly. Never cut the price of the middle tier below your cost floor from 2.1.

2.4 What to charge in 2026-27

There is no official rate card for personal training in India, and anyone who gives you one number is guessing. What exists is a verified range: metro session rates commonly run ₹500 to ₹2,500. Here is how that range maps to format and city tier, with the reasoning so you can place yourself

honestly.

Format	Metro (Delhi NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, Chennai)	Tier-2 city	What justifies the top of the band
Home visit, 1 client, 45-60 min	₹800 - ₹2,000	₹600 - ₹1,200	Travel, privacy, fully individual program
Park / society gym, 1 client	₹600 - ₹1,500	₹450 - ₹900	You cluster clients, no travel cost
Gym floor, gym's client (revenue share)	₹500 - ₹1,200 to you	₹350 - ₹800 to you	Gym provides the client and the equipment
Small group, 2-4 clients, each	₹400 - ₹900 each	₹300 - ₹600 each	Per-head price falls, hourly income rises
Online coaching, monthly	₹2,500 - ₹8,000/mo	₹1,500 - ₹5,000/mo	Program, weekly check-in, video form review
Online, premium (daily contact)	₹8,000 - ₹20,000/mo	₹5,000 - ₹12,000/mo	Only with results and references to show

Two honest notes. First, a rate is only defensible with evidence — before-and-after photos you have permission to use, reviews, a measurable client story. A ₹2,000 rate with no proof will lose to a ₹900 rate with proof, every time. Second, the range is wide because the market is fragmented and unregulated; there is no certification requirement in India to call yourself a personal trainer, so price competition from unqualified trainers is permanent. Do not compete on price with someone whose cost structure is zero because they are doing it part-time. Compete on accountability, measurement and reliability — the three things a part-timer cannot fake for twelve weeks.

> **The 15% rule**
> Raise your price by 15% once every 12 months, for new clients only, and tell existing clients their current rate is protected for one more cycle. You keep your base, you lift the average, and nobody feels cheated. A trainer who does this from year one charges 75% more by year four than a trainer who never did.

2.5 The capacity ceiling and the income table

Your income is (sessions per week × rate × 4.33) minus your costs. The sessions-per-week number is the one trainers over-estimate. A mobile trainer with 30-minute travel between clients cannot deliver more than about six sessions a day even with perfect scheduling, and five is realistic. That is 25 to 30 a week at 5-6 working days — and it is also the number at which most trainers burn out within a year.

Sessions/week	At ₹600	At ₹900	At ₹1,200	At ₹1,800
10	₹26,000	₹39,000	₹52,000	₹78,000
15	₹39,000	₹58,500	₹77,900	₹1,16,900
20	₹52,000	₹78,000	₹1,03,900	₹1,55,900
25	₹65,000	₹97,400	₹1,29,900	₹1,94,900
30	₹78,000	₹1,16,900	₹1,55,900	₹2,33,900

These are gross figures at 4.33 weeks a month, before travel, fixed costs and tax. At 25 sessions a week and ₹900 you are grossing about ₹97,400 — and after ₹18,000 of fixed costs and about ₹6,500 of travel you are near ₹73,000, which is a good living in most Indian cities. That is the honest target: not 'more clients', but 25 sessions a week at a rate that respects your cost.

Which means the growth path after that point is not more hours. It is: small-group sessions (three clients at ₹600 each is ₹1,800 an hour instead of ₹900), online coaching (delivered in the gaps, no travel), or raising the rate and dropping the two clients who pay least. All three raise income without adding a single working hour.

2.6 Packages, advances and payment terms

How you collect money matters as much as how much you charge. A trainer with a full diary and ₹60,000 of unpaid dues does not have ₹60,000; they have a collections problem and a cash-flow hole.

The four payment rules

1. **Full advance, or two instalments — never 'pay at the end of the month'.** A 12-week package is paid in full at signing, or in two halves: 60% at signing and 40% at week six. That is standard, fair and protects both sides.
2. **One receipt per payment, issued the same day.** Use the template in Part 6.6. This single habit removes 90% of 'I already paid you' conversations and gives you the record you need at tax time.
3. **Write the expiry on the package.** 'Valid for 14 weeks from start date' stops a package dragging for seven months, which destroys both your scheduling and the client's result.
4. **Missed sessions have a policy, not a mood.** Standard: 12 hours' notice to reschedule free; under 12 hours counts as used; genuine emergencies are rescheduled once, at your discretion. Put it in the agreement, say it out loud at signing, and then never argue about it again.

Why the twelve-week package is not a sales trick

Twelve weeks is the shortest period in which an untrained adult can build a visible change and a habit that survives a bad week. Selling four weeks guarantees a client who leaves just before the payoff — which is precisely the 30-45 day churn window in 1.3. The package length is a retention decision disguised as a pricing decision.

Package	Duration	Payment	Expiry	Refund if they stop
Starter, 8 sessions	4 weeks	Full advance	6 weeks	Unused sessions converted to credit, 30-day validity
Transform, 24 sessions	12 weeks	60% + 40% at week 6	14 weeks	Unused sessions refunded pro-rata minus one session
Elite, 36 sessions	12 weeks	60% + 40% at week 6	14 weeks	Unused sessions refunded pro-rata minus two sessions

Refunds: give them, quickly, when they are genuinely owed, and put the rule in writing before anyone pays. A trainer who argues about a refund loses the referral, the review and the reputation — three things worth far more than the money in dispute.

2.7 The four discount rules

Discounting is the fastest way to destroy a service business, because a discount on a service is a permanent statement about what the service is worth. If you discount at all, do it under rules.

Rule	What it means in practice
1. Discount the package, never the session	'₹16,000 for twelve weeks, and I'll add two extra check-in calls' — not '₹700 a session instead of ₹900'. The first is a bundle; the second reprices you forever.
2. Never discount below your floor	Your floor came from 2.1. Below it you are paying to work. There is no volume strategy that fixes a negative margin.
3. Trade, don't give	If they want 15% off, ask for something: payment in full today instead of instalments, a Google review at week four, two referrals, a testimonial with photos. Discounts without a trade teach the client that your first price was not real.
4. One discount, one time	A joining offer is legitimate. A discount that reappears every time they renew is just your real price, discovered slowly and painfully.

The sentence that saves your price

"I understand — the twelve-week package is a real commitment. What I can do is keep the price where it is and split the payment into three. That way you are not paying more, you are paying in smaller pieces." This answers the objection (cash flow) instead of the number (price). It works because most 'too expensive' objections in Indian personal training are actually 'too much at once'.

End of Part 2 — what to do now

Pricing is the only decision in this book that changes your income without changing your hours. Do these three things before you take another enquiry.

☐ Complete the cost worksheet in 2.1 and write your floor price on a sticky note.
☐ Write your three tiers on one page, with the middle tier named first in every conversation.
☐ Set a reminder for the same date next year: raise new-client prices by 15%.

PART 1

Client acquisition

A 30-day sprint you can run from your phone, without a marketing budget.

1

3.1 Why November to February is your season

Fitness demand in India is not flat across the year. It spikes twice and both spikes land in the next hundred days: the wedding season, which runs from late November through February, and the new-year resolution wave in the first three weeks of January. A trainer who is fully booked in March is usually a trainer who did the work in November.

Window	What is driving demand	What you should be doing
Now to 30 November	Pre-wedding clients starting 8-12 week transformations; corporates planning January wellness	Post your transformation proof daily; ask every past client for one referral; pitch two societies
1-20 December	Wedding clients mid-program; gifting-season enquiries; people planning January	Sell January packages now at a small early-bird; lock your January diary before the rush
21 December - 5 January	The resolution wave begins; enquiries spike	Answer every enquiry within the hour; run the starter offer; keep the calendar open for new slots
6-31 January	Peak enquiry volume, highest intent of the year	Convert, do not create content; your job is replies and consultations
February	Wedding season peak; clients want to look right for a date	Retention mode: measurement, photos, renewal conversations

The mistake almost every trainer makes is treating January as the start. January is when the enquiries arrive; the pipeline that converts them was built in November and December, when nobody else was posting.

3.2 The 30-day acquisition sprint

This is a 30-day plan, roughly 45 minutes a day, designed to produce five to eight qualified enquiries and two to four new clients. Do not skip days because they feel small — the small days are the ones that compound.

Day	Task	Time
1	Write your three tiers and your floor price (Part 2). Nothing else works until this is done.	90 min
2	Set up or claim your Google Business Profile. Category: Personal Trainer. Add area, hours, phone, 10 photos.	60 min
3	Message 10 past clients: 'I'm taking 3 new clients this month — is there one person you'd trust me with?' Use template 5.14.	30 min
4	Photograph your three best transformations (with written permission) and write one line about each.	45 min
5	Post transformation 1. Caption: the problem, the twelve weeks, the number that changed. No motivational quotes.	20 min
6	List every society, park and gym within 5 km. Pick the three with the most footfall.	30 min
7	Visit society 1 in person at 7 am. Speak to the security desk and any trainer on site. Ask who manages the gym.	45 min
8	Post transformation 2. Same structure.	20 min
9	Send your one-page offer to 10 people on WhatsApp — past enquirers who never bought. Template 5.13.	30 min
10	Ask your three happiest current clients for a Google review. Send the direct review link, not the profile.	20 min
11	Record a 30-second reel: one exercise, one cue, one common mistake. No music trend needed.	45 min
12	Visit society 2. Same script.	45 min
13	Post transformation 3.	20 min
14	Review: how many enquiries, how many replies, how many consultations booked? Write the numbers down.	20 min
15	Fix the weakest step. Usually it is the first reply speed, not the content.	30 min
16	Pitch one corporate: an office near you, 20 employees, a 4-week lunch-hour group block. Template 5.16.	45 min
17	Post a 'what a week with me looks like' carousel — schedule, check-ins, what you actually do.	30 min
18	Message 10 more past clients and enquirers.	30 min
19	Visit society 3.	45 min
20	Ask two current clients for a referral each, in person, at the end of a session. Template 5.14.	15 min
21	Post a client quote with their permission — the specific result, not 'great trainer'.	20 min
22	Set up a WhatsApp quick-reply library with templates 5.1-5.6 so you reply in under 5 minutes.	45 min
23	Reels: film three in one sitting. Post one, save two.	60 min
24	Follow up every unanswered enquiry from the last 30 days. Template 5.15.	30 min
25	Post reel 2.	15 min

Day	Task	Time
26	Ask five clients for a review, in person, with the link open on your phone.	20 min
27	Post reel 3.	15 min
28	Offer an early-bird January package to your whole WhatsApp status list.	20 min
29	Count: enquiries, consultations, sign-ups, revenue. Compare with day 14.	20 min
30	Keep the three tasks that produced clients. Delete the rest. Repeat monthly.	30 min

3.3 Google Business Profile in one afternoon

This is the highest-return free channel in Indian personal training and almost nobody does it properly. When someone types 'personal trainer near me' or 'fitness coach Indore', Google shows a map pack of three businesses. Being in that pack is worth more than a thousand followers, because the person searching has already decided to spend money.

The seven fields that decide whether you appear

Field	What to put	Why it matters
Primary category	Personal Trainer (not Gym, not Fitness Centre)	Category match is the strongest local ranking signal
Service area	Your actual 3-5 localities, not the whole city	Relevance to the searcher's location
Services list	Each tier as a separate service with a price range	Lets you appear for '12 week transformation' style searches
Photos	10 minimum: you training someone, the space, equipment, a before/after with permission	Profiles with photos get materially more calls
Hours	Real hours, updated when they change	'Open now' filtering hides inaccurate profiles
Phone + WhatsApp link	One number, used consistently everywhere	Every inconsistency costs a call
Reviews	Ask for them in person, weekly, with the direct link	Review count and recency drive the map pack

The review ask that works

"I don't have a website — Google is my shopfront. Would you mind leaving me two lines? It takes about a minute and it's the only way people find me." Then hand them your phone with the review form already open. The ask works because it is true, specific and takes no effort from them.

Reply to every review within 48 hours, including the bad ones. A calm, specific reply to a two-star review converts more readers than ten five-star reviews, because it shows how you behave when something goes wrong.

3.4 The twelve-post Instagram grid

Instagram works for trainers, but not the way most trainers use it. Motivation quotes and shirtless mirror photos do not sell coaching; they attract other trainers. What sells is proof, process and personality, in that order, and it can be planned as a repeating twelve-post cycle.

#	Post type	What it looks like	What it proves
1	Transformation	Before/after with permission, the number that changed, the timeframe	You deliver results
2	Process	A carousel: what a typical week with you includes	They know what they are buying
3	Cue video	30-second reel, one exercise, one correction	You know your craft
4	Client quote	Their words, their specific result, their photo	Other people trust you
5	Myth	'Spot reduction doesn't work — here's what does' with a demo	You will not waste their time
6	Day in the life	5 am start, the travel, the last session	You are reliable
7	Beginner guide	'First 4 weeks for a complete beginner' carousel	You handle beginners
8	Local	A park or society you train at, tagged	You are nearby
9	Offer	Your three tiers, plainly priced	How to buy
10	Objection	'I travel for work — here's how we handle it'	You solve real problems
11	Behind the plan	How you write a program, on screen	You are not guessing
12	Ask	'Taking 3 clients this month, DM me'	A clear call to action

Four formats are enough: a 30-second reel, a 6-slide carousel, a single photo with a real caption, and a screenshot of a client message (with permission and the name hidden). Rotate them. Post four times a week at most; consistency beats volume, and a trainer who posts daily for two weeks and then vanishes for two months looks worse than one who posts twice a week forever.

One practical note: reels of real clients training in real Indian settings outperform studio-perfect content, because the viewer is trying to imagine themselves in your session. A phone camera, good light and a clear cue are enough.

3.5 WhatsApp: status, broadcast and the 24-hour rule

In India, WhatsApp is not a marketing channel — it is where the sale actually happens. Treat it as your shop counter.

- **Status, daily, free.** One clip of a session, one client win, one slot opening. Seen by exactly the people who saved your number. This is the cheapest attention available to an Indian trainer and it converts because it is not an ad.
- **Broadcast, twice a month maximum.** One useful message (a tip, a schedule change) and one offer. More than that and you get muted, which is permanent.

- **The 24-hour rule.** Every enquiry gets a reply within one hour during your working day and within 24 hours otherwise, no exceptions. In fitness, the first good answer usually wins the client — enquiries are messaging three trainers at once.
- **Voice notes for hesitation.** When a client is nervous or confused, a 40-second voice note outperforms three paragraphs of text, because tone carries reassurance that typing cannot.
- **Never quote a final price before the consultation.** 'It depends on what you need — 20 minutes on a call and I'll tell you exactly' is not evasion; it is the truth, and it moves the conversation to the right place.

3.6 The referral engine

Referrals are the highest-converting channel you have and the one most trainers never ask for. The reason is simple: asking feels like begging. It stops feeling that way when you ask with a specific script, at a specific moment, for a specific thing.

The three asks

Ask	When	Script	Why it works
The timing ask	Immediately after a session where they did something they could not do a month ago	"You just did something in week five that you couldn't do in week one. If you know one person who needs that, send them my number — I'll take care of the rest."	They are feeling the value at that exact moment
The specific ask	At the end of week 8	"Most of my clients come from people like you. Is there one person at work or home who's been saying they want to start?"	'One person' is easy to answer; 'anyone you know' is not
The reciprocal ask	After they renew	"Thank you — that means a lot. Two things that would help me: a Google review, and one name if someone comes to mind."	They have just committed, so the relationship feels settled

Do not offer cash for referrals unless you have to. A ₹500 credit for a signed package is standard and fine, but the trainers who get the most referrals are the ones who simply ask, in person, at the right moment, without a scheme. What kills referrals is asking once and never again — ask at every renewal.

3.7 Offline: societies, parks and corporates

For home and park trainers, offline is not old-fashioned — it is where the density is. A single large society can hold twenty potential clients, all within a five-minute walk, which turns your travel cost to near zero and your session capacity up by half.

The society approach

1. Go at 6:30-7:30 am on a weekday, when residents are actually walking and the gym is in use.
2. Speak to the security desk first — they decide whether you get in. Be polite, be specific: 'I coach residents here, I'd like to speak to whoever manages the gym.'
3. If there is a society gym, find the committee member or secretary. Offer something free and real: a 45-minute 'form check' session for residents on a Sunday morning.

4. Bring a one-page sheet: your name, photo, three tiers, one transformation, your phone number and a QR code to your Google profile. Leave ten.
5. Ask for the residents' WhatsApp group admin. A single message in a 300-member society group is worth a month of reels — but only post with the admin's permission, once.

The corporate pitch

Offices near you are a genuinely underserved channel, especially in November when HR teams are planning January wellness spends. You are not selling to the company's budget; you are selling a lunch-hour group block that employees pay for themselves, with the company providing the room.

CORPORATE WHATSAPP / EMAIL PITCH

Hello [Name], I'm [Your name], a personal trainer working in [area]. I run 45-minute lunch-hour strength sessions for small office groups — 4 to 8 people, no equipment needed beyond a mat and a resistance band, done in a meeting room or terrace.

I'm offering two offices near [landmark] a free trial session for up to six employees in the first week of [month]. If it works, the block is ₹[X] per person per session, paid by each employee directly, so there's no budget approval needed on your side.

Would a 10-minute call this week be useful? I can send a one-page outline first if that's easier.

The reason this pitch works is the last line of the second paragraph: you have removed the procurement problem. HR can say yes to something that costs the company nothing and makes them look good.

3.8 The first reply: five enquiry scripts

Most enquiries are lost in the first message. These five cover the situations that actually come up. Copy them into your WhatsApp quick replies and edit the brackets.

5.1 THE PRICE-FIRST ENQUIRY

"Hi [Name], thanks for messaging. Before I quote you — are you training for something specific (a wedding, a health report, getting back into it), and how many days a week can you realistically do? Prices depend on that, and I'd rather give you the right number than a wrong one."

5.2 'KITNA LAGEGA?' IN ONE LINE

"Depends on the format, so let me be straight: park or home sessions near you run [₹X]-[₹Y] a session, and most people do a 12-week block. If you tell me your goal and days, I'll send the exact package and price in one message — no calls needed unless you want one."

5.3 THE HESITANT 'LET ME THINK ABOUT IT'

"Completely fair. Can I ask what's making you pause — the price, the time, or whether it'll actually work? I ask because each one has a different answer, and if it's the third one I'd rather show you two client stories than talk you into anything."

5.4 OUT OF BUDGET

"Thank you for being honest — that helps. Two options: a smaller block of 8 sessions at [₹X] so you can start and see, or a 2-person group with [name/another client] at [₹Y] each. If neither works, tell me your ceiling and I'll tell you honestly whether I can deliver anything real at that number."

5.5 OUT OF AREA

"I don't cover [area] — my clients are all within 5 km of [locality] so I can be on time. Two options: online coaching (program + weekly video check-ins, [₹X]/month), or I can ask around for a trainer I'd trust in [area]. Want me to do that?"

The rule behind all five

Never answer a price question with a price. Answer it with a question that gets you the information to quote correctly, and then quote once, in writing, with what is included. Trainers who quote in the first message spend the rest of the conversation discounting.

3.9 The 20-minute consultation that closes

If you do the consultation well you will close most of the people you speak to, because by the end the client has described their own problem in their own words and heard you describe a plan for it. Structure it in five blocks and keep to time.

Minutes	Block	What you do	What you are listening for
0-3	Frame it	"I'll ask a few questions, then tell you honestly whether I can help and what it costs. If I can't help, I'll say so."	Nothing — you are setting the tone
3-9	Their story	Why now? What have they tried? What stopped them? What does success look like in twelve weeks?	The real goal behind the stated goal
9-13	Constraints	Days, timings, travel, budget ceiling, injuries, doctor's advice, family support	Whether they can actually show up
13-17	The plan	Three sentences: what you would do, in what order, and what the first two weeks look like	Whether they lean in
17-20	The close	Name the tier that fits, state the price, state what happens next, ask for the decision	Any hesitation you need to name

THE CLOSE

"Based on what you've told me — [goal], [days] a week, and the [constraint] — the fit is the twelve-week package: [X] sessions, [what's included], [₹Y]. The first session is [day/time]. I'll send you the agreement and the health form now; once that's signed and the advance is in, that slot is yours. Does [day/time] work, or shall I look at Thursday instead?"

Two things in that close do the work. It assumes the decision ('the fit is') rather than asking whether they want to buy, and it ends with a choice between two days rather than between yes and no. Neither is a trick; both simply keep the conversation moving toward a calendar, which is

where a coaching relationship actually begins.

And when they say no: ask one question — 'what would have made this a yes?' Write the answer down. Ten noes will tell you more about your offer than ten yeses.

End of Part 3 — what to do now

Acquisition is a sprint, not a mood. Run the 30-day plan once and you will have a repeatable month rather than a lucky one.

☐ Book 45 minutes a day for 30 days in your calendar, starting tomorrow.
☐ Set up WhatsApp quick replies for templates 5.1 to 5.6 today — reply speed is the single biggest conversion lever.
☐ Ask three current clients for a Google review this week, in person, with the link open.

PART 1

The 90-day lifecycle

The system that turns a 60% drop-off into a twelve-month client.

1

4.1 The touchpoint map

Retention is not a personality trait; it is a calendar. Below is the full map. Every row is a contact you initiate — not one you wait for. Print it, and for each client write their name against the date.

When	Touchpoint	Channel	What it is for
Before day 1	Welcome message + forms + first session details	WhatsApp	Remove every reason to no-show
Day 0	Session one: baseline photos, measurements, one small win	In person	Give them a number to beat
Day 1	Follow-up: 'how are the legs?'	WhatsApp	The single most predictive message in the whole system
Day 7	Week-one check + next week's schedule locked	Call or voice note	Catch the first wobble
Day 14	Form check video + one adjustment	WhatsApp	Show that the plan is being managed
Day 30	Measurement ritual + progress note	In person	The first proof point
Day 45	Plateau conversation	In person	Pre-empt the 45-day exit
Day 60	Renewal close	In person	Sell the next block before the last session
Day 75	Next-block onboarding + new goal set	WhatsApp	Momentum into block two
Day 90	Review, testimonial ask, referral ask	In person	Convert satisfaction into proof and pipeline

Ten touchpoints in ninety days, of which only four happen in a session you were already being paid for. The other six take about fifteen minutes each. That is two and a half hours of unpaid work per client per quarter — and it is the highest-paid work you will ever do, because it is the difference between ₹16,000 once and ₹64,000 across a year.

4.2 Week zero: the first 48 hours

A client decides whether they trust you in the first two sessions, and whether they will stay in the first two weeks. Week zero is therefore not admin — it is the most important part of the program.

- ☐ Send the welcome message within two hours of payment (template 5.7). Include the first session date, time, exact address, what to wear, what to bring and your phone number.
- ☐ Send the intake form and health screen (Part 6) and ask for them back before session one. If they do not return them, ask again once — the form is also a commitment device.
- ☐ Confirm the session the evening before, every time, for the first four sessions. No-show rates fall by more than half with a same-evening confirmation.
- ☐ Session one: 10 minutes of conversation, 30 minutes of movement, 5 minutes of paperwork. Do not test their maximum; give them one thing they can do well.
- ☐ Take baseline measurements and photos with written consent, or explicitly agree not to. Never take photos without permission, and never post them without a separate, specific permission.

- ☐ Agree the weekly schedule in writing — days and times for the next four weeks, in one message they can scroll back to.
- ☐ Send the day-one follow-up the next morning. This message is the cheapest retention insurance you will ever buy.

5.7 WELCOME MESSAGE

Hi [Name], welcome aboard. Three things:

1. First session: [day], [time] at [exact address / landmark]. Wear shoes you can move in, bring water. I'll bring the band and the mat.
2. Before we start, please fill these two forms — they take 6 minutes and one of them is a health screen I genuinely need: [links]
3. Between now and then, don't change anything. No diet, no extra cardio. We start on [day] and I'd rather see your normal week than a perfect three days.

My number is [X] — message me any time before then if something comes up.

4.3 Day 7, 14 and 30 check-ins

These three messages do most of the retention work in the whole system. They are short, specific and about the client's experience rather than your program.

DAY 1 (THE MOST IMPORTANT MESSAGE)

"Morning [Name] — how are the legs today? Whatever you're feeling is normal for week one and it fades by day four. Don't add anything today; just walk. See you [day]."

DAY 7

"Quick week-one check: what was hardest, and what surprised you? Two things I want to lock before week two — [day] and [day] at [time]. Reply with a yes and they're in my calendar."

DAY 14

"Sent you a 40-second video on your squat — your knees are tracking better than week one, which is exactly what I wanted to see by now. One change for this week: [specific cue]. Keep everything else the same."

DAY 30 MEASUREMENT

"Day 30 numbers: [measurement] down [X], [measurement] up [Y], and you did [Z] sessions out of 8 — that consistency is the actual result here. Photos on [day] so you can see it side by side. What's one thing you want to be different by day 60?"

The day-30 rule

Never let a client reach day 30 without seeing a number move. If the scale has not moved, show them something else that has: a rep count, a photo, a waist measurement, a stair climb, a sleep score. If genuinely nothing has moved, say so honestly and change the plan — that conversation, held at day 30, saves the client. Held at day 60, it loses them.

4.4 The measurement ritual

Clients stay for progress they can see, not progress they can feel. Give progress a ritual so it happens on schedule rather than when someone remembers.

Measure	How	How often	Why this one
Weight	Same scale, same time, morning, after the toilet, before food	Weekly, but only discussed monthly	Easy to record, terrible to over-interpret
Waist at navel	Same tape, same landmark, relaxed exhale	Every 4 weeks	The most honest single number for fat change
Photos: front, side, back	Same spot, same light, same clothing, same time of day	Every 4 weeks	The only measure that matches what the mirror says
Strength benchmark	One lift or movement, fixed reps or fixed weight	Every 4 weeks	Proves the training is working even when the scale stalls
Sessions completed vs planned	Count them	Weekly	The number that predicts every other number
Sleep and steps	Phone or watch, weekly average	Weekly	Explains most 'unexplained' plateaus

Keep the photos on your own device, in a folder per client, and delete them when the client leaves — unless they have given you specific, written permission to use them in marketing. Consent for measurement is not consent for promotion, and a trainer who confuses the two will eventually lose a client, a review and possibly more.

4.5 Day 45: the plateau conversation

Around week six or seven, almost every client hits something: the scale stalls, work gets busy, a wedding or a trip breaks the rhythm, or the initial excitement simply wears off. This is the single highest-risk moment in the relationship, and it is entirely predictable — which means you can schedule the conversation instead of reacting to a message that says 'I think I need a break'.

DAY 45 PLATEAU CONVERSATION

"Before we start today — I want to name something that happens to almost everyone around week six. The first month gives you fast, visible change; the second month gives you change you can't see yet. That's not a plateau, that's the middle. Three things I'm changing for weeks 7-12: [change 1], [change 2], and I'm adding a [measurement] so you can see it. What's the one thing that's been hardest to keep up outside our sessions?"

Three moves in that message, and each one matters. You named the experience before they had to complain about it, which removes the shame of 'failing'. You changed something, which proves the plan is not a photocopy. And you asked a question that gets you the real obstacle — usually sleep, food or family, rarely the training.

4.6 Day 60: the renewal close

The renewal conversation happens at day 60, not at the last session. By the last session the client has already decided, and their decision was made in the two weeks when nobody asked them. Ask early, ask plainly, and give three options.

DAY 60 RENEWAL

"You're at session 16 of 24, so we've got three weeks left — which means it's time to decide what the next twelve weeks look like. Three options:

1. Continue as you are: another 24-session block, same days, same rate.
2. Step up: 36 sessions and a nutrition check-in every fortnight, if you want to push for [their specific goal] before [their date].
3. Step down: 8 sessions a month for maintenance, if the budget or the calendar is tight right now.

Most people in your position take option 1. Which one sounds right?"

Why three options and not a yes/no: a yes/no invites 'let me think about it', which is a no with better manners. Three options invite a choice, and any choice is a renewal. Notice too that option 3 exists — a smaller renewal is always better than a lost client, because it keeps the relationship, the referral and the review alive.

Never say 'your package is finishing'

That sentence puts an ending in the client's head. Say 'you're at session 16 of 24, so let's plan the next twelve weeks'. Same facts, opposite direction.

4.7 Five churn saves

These are the five situations that account for most lost clients. Each has a script and a principle.

Situation	What they say	What you say	The principle
Missed sessions piling up	"I've been travelling, let's pause"	"Let's not pause — let's shrink. Two sessions a week instead of three for the next month, and I'll hold the unused sessions for you. Pausing is how people lose the habit entirely."	Reduce, never pause
'No results'	"I'm not seeing anything"	"That's fair to say. Let me show you the numbers from day 1 — [X] down, [Y] up. If the mirror isn't matching the numbers, then the plan needs changing, not you. Here's what I'd change."	Show data, then change something
Money pressure	"This is getting expensive"	"I hear you. Option one: 8 sessions a month instead of 12 at [₹X]. Option two: two-person sessions with [name] at [₹Y] each. Both keep you training; neither is a discount on what I do."	Change the format, not the rate
Moving city	"We're relocating in March"	"Then let's use the time properly — 8 weeks of in-person, then I'll set you up with a program and monthly video check-ins online. And I'll ask around for someone I'd trust in [city]."	Convert to online, don't end
Ghosting	No reply for 10 days	"[Name], I'm not chasing — I just don't want you to lose the 6 sessions you've paid for. Are you okay? If the timing's wrong, tell me and I'll hold them till [date]."	Assume a reason, not an insult

The ghosting message deserves a note. Most trainers send 'hi, are you coming?' and get silence. The message above works because it leads with the client's money rather than your schedule, asks a human question, and gives them an easy way back that does not require an apology. Roughly half of ghosted clients return to a message like this.

4.8 Why one long client beats three short ones

The maths of retention is brutal and it is worth doing once, properly, so you never again prioritise a new enquiry over a current client.

	Short-client model	Long-client model
Average client stay	10 weeks (one block)	48 weeks (four blocks)
Revenue per client	₹16,000	₹64,000
New clients needed for ₹1,60,000 of revenue	10	2.5
Cost of acquiring each	5-10x a renewal	Referral + review
Unpaid acquisition hours for that revenue	~40 hours	~10 hours
Revenue per hour worked	Low and falling	High and rising

One client who stays a year is worth four who leave at ten weeks, and costs you roughly a quarter of the acquisition effort. That is why Part 4 comes before Part 3 in importance even though it comes after it in the book. The trainer who keeps clients does not need a bigger funnel; the trainer who loses them needs a bigger funnel every single month, forever.

End of Part 4 — what to do now

Retention is the cheapest revenue you will ever earn. Two and a half hours a month per client buys you a year instead of a quarter.

☐ Put every current client on the tracker in 9.4 with their real dates.
☐ Send the day-7, day-14 and day-30 messages to anyone who is overdue for one.
☐ Book the day-60 renewal conversation for your longest-standing client, in your calendar, now.

PART 1

40 message templates

Copy, edit the brackets, send. Written the way Indian clients actually read WhatsApp.

1

5.1 Enquiry and first contact (1-6)

Templates 5.1 to 5.6 are in Part 3.8, where the enquiry conversation is covered in full. Read them there first.

5.6 THE OUT-OF-HOURS AUTO-REPLY
"Thanks for messaging — I'm with a client until [time]. I'll reply properly by [time]. If it's urgent, call me on [number]."

5.2 Onboarding (7-12)

5.8 FORMS REMINDER
"Hi [Name] — just the two forms before [day]: [link]. The health screen matters most; if anything on it is a yes, we'll talk it through before we start rather than after."

5.9 FIRST-SESSION CONFIRMATION
"Confirming tomorrow: [day], [time], [address]. I'll be there 5 minutes early. If you're running late, message me — 10 minutes is fine, beyond that we'll need to shorten the session."

5.10 SCHEDULE LOCK
"Your four weeks, locked: [day] [time], [day] [time], [day] [time], [day] [time]. Screenshot this. Any change needs 12 hours' notice and I'll move it; under 12 hours it counts as used, which is the rule we agreed."

5.11 WHAT TO EXPECT IN WEEK ONE
"Week one, honestly: you'll be sore on day 2 and 3, it fades by day 5, and you'll sleep better by day 4. Don't add cardio, don't cut food — I want to see your normal week first. Nothing you do this week needs to be perfect."

5.12 PAYMENT RECEIVED
"Received ₹[X] for the [package] — receipt attached, package valid till [date]. Thank you. Session 1 is [day] at [time]."

5.3 Re-engagement (13-16)

5.13 PAST ENQUIRER REVIVAL
"Hi [Name] — you asked about training in [month] and the timing wasn't right. I've got two slots opening in [month] and I'm taking three new clients. If you're still thinking about it, reply and I'll send the details; if not, tell me and I'll stop messaging."

5.14 REFERRAL ASK
"Quick one: I'm taking two new clients this month. Is there one person you'd trust me with — someone at home or work who's been saying they want to start? I'll look after them properly."

5.15 UNANSWERED ENQUIRY FOLLOW-UP
"Hi [Name], following up once in case my last message got buried. If now isn't the time, no problem at all — just reply 'later' and I'll check back in [month]."

5.16 CORPORATE PITCH
See 3.7 for the full version. Short form: "Hello [Name], I run 45-minute lunch-hour strength sessions for office groups of 4-8 in [area]. Free trial for up to six employees first week of [month], then ₹[X] per person per session paid by employees directly — no budget approval needed on your side. 10-minute call this week?"

5.4 In-program (17-26)

5.17 DAY-AFTER-SESSION CHECK
"How's the [body part] today? Normal to feel it 24-48 hours. Walk 20 minutes, drink water, no extra training. See you [day]."

5.18 MISSED SESSION, SAME DAY
"Missed you today — everything okay? Your slot's held till [time] tomorrow if you can make it; otherwise it counts as used per our agreement, but tell me what happened and I'll see what I can do."

5.19 TRAVEL WEEK PLAN
"You're in [city] Tue-Fri. Here's the hotel-room version: [3 exercises, sets and reps]. Two sessions, 20 minutes each. Send me a video of set 2 and I'll correct your form."

5.20 ILLNESS OR INJURY
"Stop training until [condition]. I'm not a doctor and I won't guess at this — if it's still there in 48 hours, get it looked at. Send me the doctor's note or advice and I'll rebuild the plan around it. Your sessions don't expire while you're unwell."

5.21 FESTIVAL WEEK
"Diwali week: two sessions instead of three, both before [date]. Food: eat what's served, keep protein at each meal, walk after dinner. One week does not undo twelve."

5.22 PROGRESS NOTE
"Week [X] note: [measurement] down [A], [benchmark] up [B], [C] of [D] sessions done. The thing that's working is [specific]. The thing we're changing is [specific]."

5.23 FORM CORRECTION VIDEO
"40-second video on your [lift]: [cue]. Your [issue] is fixed; now watch the [second issue]. Practise it with an empty bar before [day]."

5.24 PRAISE THAT LANDS
"You did [specific thing] today that you couldn't do in week one. That's not the scale, that's you getting stronger. Worth noticing."

5.25 RESET AFTER A BAD WEEK
"One bad week doesn't reset anything — it's data. What happened: [their reason]. What we do: [one change]. Back on [day], same time. Nothing to make up."

5.26 PHOTO REMINDER
"Photos on [day] — same spot, same light, same clothes. Takes two minutes and it's the only way you'll see what's actually changed."

5.5 Money (27-32)

5.27 SECOND INSTALMENT DUE
"Friendly reminder: the second instalment of ₹[X] is due on [date]. UPI to [id] or the same account as before. I'll send the receipt the moment it lands."

5.28 OVERDUE, DAY 3
"Hi [Name] — the ₹[X] from [date] hasn't come through. If it's gone to a different account, send me the reference and I'll check. If the timing's difficult, tell me and we'll split it — I'd rather know than wonder."

5.29 OVERDUE, DAY 10
"[Name], I need to pause sessions from [date] until the ₹[X] is settled — I can't keep training on an open balance. Nothing is lost; your remaining sessions stay on hold. Let's fix it this week."

5.30 PRICE RISE TO EXISTING CLIENT
"A note before your next renewal: my rate for new clients goes up to ₹[X] from [date]. Your current rate is protected for this next block, and the one after that will be at the new rate. I wanted you to hear it from me first."

5.31 REFUND, AGREED
"Refunding ₹[X] for the [N] unused sessions today — it should reach you in 2-3 working days. Thank you for telling me directly; I'd rather part properly than badly."

5.32 ADVANCE FOR A NEW BLOCK
"Thanks for renewing — ₹[X] received, receipt attached. New block runs [start] to [end], [N] sessions, same days. Nothing changes except your [new goal]."

5.6 Reviews, referrals and endings (33-40)

5.33 REVIEW ASK, IN PERSON FOLLOW-UP
"As I mentioned today — here's the link, it takes a minute: [link]. Two lines about what changed is plenty."

5.34 TESTIMONIAL WITH PHOTOS
"Would you be okay with me using your before/after on Instagram? I'd use first name only, no other details, and you can say no with no awkwardness. If yes, I'll send exactly what I plan to post before it goes up."

5.35 REFERRAL THANK-YOU
"[Name] came to see me today and mentioned you sent them. Thank you — that means a lot. Your next session is on the house."

5.36 CLIENT FINISHING WELL
"Last session of the block today. Here's your 12-week summary: [numbers]. You've got a program for the next month in your folder — [details]. If you want to come back in [month], message me and I'll hold a slot."

5.37 CLIENT LEAVING UNHAPPY
"I'd rather hear it than not. What didn't work? I'm not going to argue — I want to know what I got wrong, and if a refund is fair, it's fair."

5.38 HOLIDAY CLOSURE
"I'm away [dates]. Sessions resume [date]. Your package expiry moves by the same number of days, so nothing is lost. Meanwhile: [simple 2-session plan]."

5.39 WAITLIST MESSAGE
"I'm full until [date]. Want me to hold the first slot that opens? Reply 'hold' and I'll message you before I offer it to anyone else."

5.40 THE 'NO' REPLY
"Understood, and thank you for telling me rather than going quiet. If anything changes, my door's open. If you know someone who's looking, I'd be grateful for the introduction."

End of Part 5 — what to do now

Forty templates is a library, not a script. Load the six you will use most into WhatsApp quick replies and the rest into a notes file you can search.

☐ Copy templates 5.1, 5.3, 5.7, 5.14, 5.27 and 5.33 into your quick replies.
☐ Rewrite each in your own words once — a template that sounds like you gets replies.
☐ Delete the ones you will never use. A library you cannot search is not a library.

PART 1

The paperwork pack

Eight documents that protect you, your client and your income. Photocopy and use.

1

6.1 What you need, and why

In India there is no licensing requirement to practise as a personal trainer, which means the only thing standing between you and a serious problem is paperwork you wrote yourself. These eight documents take an afternoon to adapt and then serve you for years.

Document	When it is used	What it protects
Intake form (6.2)	Before session one	You know who you are training and what they want
Health screen (6.3)	Before session one, every 12 months	You spot risk and refer out instead of guessing
Consent and scope (6.4)	At signing	Everyone knows what you do and do not do
Package agreement (6.5)	At signing	Price, sessions, expiry, cancellation are all agreed
Payment receipt (6.6)	Every payment	Proof for the client, records for your tax return
Cancellation and refund policy (6.7)	At signing	Ends the argument before it starts
Photo and marketing consent (6.8)	Separately, at signing	You can market without ever guessing
Session log (6.9)	Every session	Shows you were diligent, and shows the client progress

The honest limit

These templates are a starting point written for Indian independent trainers. They are not legal advice and they are not a substitute for a lawyer if a dispute turns serious or if you are running a studio with employees. Use them, adapt them to your business, and get a local advocate to review the agreement once if your annual revenue crosses a few lakh.

Send the intake form with the welcome message, not on the day. Ten minutes of typing before session one replaces twenty minutes of guessing during it, and the answers decide what the first four weeks actually look like. Read the completed form before you write the program — not after.

6.2 Client intake form

CLIENT INTAKE FORM

Full name: _____ Age: _____ Gender: _____
Phone / WhatsApp: _____ Email: _____
City and locality: _____ Occupation: _____
Emergency contact: _____ Relationship: _____ Phone: _____

Why are you starting now? _____
_____
What have you tried before (gym, classes, home workouts, apps)? _____
_____
What stopped it? _____

Your goal in the next 12 weeks: _____
How will you know it worked? (a number, a photo, a task, a feeling) _____

Days per week you can train: _____ Preferred times: _____
Any fixed commitments (travel, shift work, caregiving)? _____
Current activity level: sedentary / light / moderate / active
Average sleep: _____ hours Steps per day: _____ Water: _____ litres

Doctor you see regularly: _____ Last full check-up: _____

Signed: _____ Date: _____

Two questions on that form do more work than the rest. 'How will you know it worked?' turns a vague wish into a measurable goal you can be judged against. 'What stopped it last time?' tells you exactly what will stop it this time, so you can build the plan around the obstacle instead of discovering it in week five.

Ask for it back before session one, every time, even for a client who looks fit and has trained for years. Read the answers yourself rather than glancing at them: the whole document is useless if you skim it. Where an answer is yes, the next section tells you exactly what to do.

6.3 Health screen

This is the most important document in the pack. It is adapted from the standard PAR-Q screening questionnaire used across the fitness industry, and it is not a medical assessment: it does not make you a clinician; it is a short screening tool whose only job is to tell you when to stop and send someone to a doctor. Ask every client to complete it before session one and again every twelve months, and read it before you write a single program.

HEALTH SCREEN — answer every question

Has a doctor ever told you that you have a heart condition, or that you should only do physical activity recommended by a doctor? YES / NO

Do you feel pain in your chest when you do physical activity? YES / NO

In the past month, have you had chest pain when you were not doing physical activity? YES / NO

Do you lose your balance because of dizziness, or do you ever lose consciousness? YES / NO

Do you have a bone or joint problem that could be made worse by a change in your physical activity? YES / NO

Is your doctor currently prescribing drugs for blood pressure or a heart condition? YES / NO

Do you know of any other reason you should not do physical activity? YES / NO

Are you pregnant, or have you given birth in the last 6 months? YES / NO

Do you have diabetes, thyroid, kidney or any diagnosed metabolic condition? YES / NO

Are you currently taking any medication, supplement or steroid? YES / NO

If yes to any: describe _____

Client signature: _____ Date: _____
Trainer reviewed on: _____ Trainer: _____

The rule, stated plainly

If the answer to any question is yes — and especially the first seven — the client needs a doctor's clearance before you train them. Not a conversation, not a promise to be careful: written clearance, or a specific instruction from their doctor about what they may and may not do. This is not over-caution. It is the difference between a trainer and a liability, and it is also the professional standard any reputable certification body will teach you.

There is a second, harder rule that no form can soften: you are not a doctor, a physiotherapist or a dietitian. You do not diagnose pain, you do not prescribe diets, and you do not tell anyone to stop or change medication. When a client describes pain, the correct response is to stop, ask where and when it hurts, and send them to a professional — then rebuild the program around whatever that professional says. The full scope-of-practice list is in 6.4.

The consent form does two jobs. It tells the client, in writing, what they are taking on — and it tells you, in writing, what you are not. The second job is the one that matters when something goes wrong, and it is also the one that makes you look like a professional rather than an enthusiast.

6.4 Consent and scope of practice

This is the document that stops a bad outcome becoming a legal problem, and it takes ten minutes to adapt.

CONSENT AND SCOPE OF PRACTICE

I, _____, am voluntarily participating in a personal training program with _____ (the trainer).

1. SCOPE. The trainer provides exercise instruction, program design, technique coaching and habit support. The trainer is not a doctor, physiotherapist, dietitian, nutritionist or psychologist, and does not diagnose, treat or cure any condition.

2. RISK. I understand that exercise carries inherent risk of injury, and that I am responsible for disclosing any medical condition, medication, pregnancy, injury or pain before training begins and as soon as it arises.

3. CLEARANCE. Where my health screen indicates a condition, I will provide written clearance from my doctor before starting, and will follow any restriction my doctor advises.

4. PAIN. I will stop immediately and tell the trainer if I feel chest pain, dizziness, faintness or sharp joint pain.

5. NUTRITION. Any nutrition guidance given is general and habit-based, and is not a prescribed diet. Where I need a clinical diet plan, I will consult a registered dietitian.

6. DATA. The trainer may keep my measurements, photos and session records. These are used for my program only, are not shared with third parties, and will be deleted on request.

7. MARKETING. Please tick one: [ ] I allow use of my photos in marketing (first name only) [ ] No, do not use my photos or story anywhere.

Signed (client): _____ Date: _____
Signed (trainer): _____ Date: _____

What a trainer may and may not do

You may	You may not
Design and progress an exercise program	Diagnose an injury or a condition
Coach technique, load and recovery	Prescribe a therapeutic diet or supplements
Give general, habit-level food guidance	Tell a client to stop or change medication
Ask for and act on a doctor's clearance	Train someone who needs clearance but has not provided it
Measure, photograph (with consent) and track	Use a client's photos or story without specific consent
Refer out to a doctor, physio or dietitian	Treat, manipulate or 'fix' a joint
Say 'this is outside what I do'	Guess when you do not know

One page, eight clauses, signed before the first payment. Do not use a template you have not read aloud to yourself — if you cannot explain a clause in one sentence, the client cannot agree to it either.

6.5 Package agreement

PERSONAL TRAINING AGREEMENT

Trainer: _____ Phone: _____
Client: _____ Phone: _____
Start date: _____ Package: _____ Sessions: _____
Days and times: _____
Location: _____

1. FEE. Total fee ₹_____ (in words: _____),
payable as: ₹_____ on signing and ₹_____ on _____.

2. VALIDITY. This package is valid for _____ weeks from the start date. Sessions not used within that period lapse, except where the trainer agrees in writing to extend (illness, travel, or trainer unavailability).

3. RESCHEDULING. 12 hours' notice is required to reschedule a session at no cost. With less notice, the session counts as delivered. Genuine emergencies will be considered once at the trainer's discretion.

4. CANCELLATION BY CLIENT. Unused sessions are refunded pro-rata, less one session as an administration fee, on written request.

5. CANCELLATION BY TRAINER. If the trainer cannot continue, all unused sessions are refunded in full within 7 working days, or transferred to another trainer with the client's agreement.

6. LATE ARRIVAL. Sessions end at the scheduled time. Arrivals more than 15 minutes late may be shortened or treated as missed.

7. HEALTH. The client confirms the health screen has been completed truthfully and that any required doctor's clearance has been provided.

8. CONDUCT. Either party may end this agreement for inappropriate conduct, with unused sessions refunded pro-rata.

Client signature: _____ Date: _____
Trainer signature: _____ Date: _____

Read clause 2 and clause 3 out loud at signing. Every dispute you will ever have with a client is about one of those two things — the package dragging past its dates, or a session that was missed without notice — and both are solved by thirty seconds of saying it plainly while the client is happy.

Issue a receipt the same day, every time, including for cash and including for a friend. The receipt is your client's proof, your record for the tax return in Part 7, and — quietly — the thing that makes people pay on time, because it signals that you keep accounts.

6.6 Payment receipt and dues policy

PAYMENT RECEIPT

Receipt no.: _____ Date: _____
Received from: _____
Amount: ₹_____ (in words: _____)
Mode: UPI / bank transfer / cash Reference: _____
For: _____ package, _____ sessions, _____ weeks
Package valid till: _____ Balance due: ₹_____ on _____

Received by: _____ Signature: _____

This is a receipt for services. It is not a tax invoice. Where GST registration applies, a tax invoice with GSTIN and SAC 999723 is issued separately.

The dues policy that works

- **Nothing starts on credit.** The first session happens after the advance, not before. This is not distrust; it is the same rule every professional follows.
- **Instalments get a date in writing** — in the agreement, not in a WhatsApp message that scrolls away.
- **Day 3, day 10, then pause.** One reminder, one firmer reminder, then sessions pause until the balance clears. Say this at signing so the sequence is expected.
- **Never train on an open balance for more than two weeks.** The longer it runs, the less likely it is to be paid, and the more resentful you become — which the client can feel.

Write it once, put it in the agreement, and then never argue about it again. The value of a refund policy is not the refunds it avoids; it is the arguments it prevents, and the confidence it gives a nervous first-time client that they are not walking into a trap.

6.7 Cancellation and refund policy

CANCELLATION AND REFUND POLICY

Before the first session: 100% refund, no questions asked.

After the first session: unused sessions refunded pro-rata, less one session as an administration fee, on written request within 7 days of the request.

Where the client stops for medical reasons supported by a doctor's note: unused sessions refunded in full, or held as credit for up to 6 months.

Where the trainer is unavailable: unused sessions refunded in full within 7 working days, or rescheduled at the client's choice.

Refunds are paid to the original payment method within 7 working days.

Where a client is dissatisfied with the service, the trainer will discuss it in good faith before any refund decision, and will not withhold a fair refund to avoid a conversation.

That last clause is unusual and deliberate. A refund policy is a trust document, not a legal shield; the trainers who refund quickly and without argument get the reviews, the referrals and the reputation that no marketing budget can buy. The trainers who fight over ₹2,000 lose ₹40,000 of future business and never find out.

Before-and-after photos are the most powerful marketing a trainer has, and the fastest way to lose a client's trust if they were taken for one purpose and used for another. Separate consent, sent for approval before posting, costs you two minutes per client.

6.8 Photo and marketing consent

Keep this separate from the main consent. A client agreeing to be measured has not agreed to appear on Instagram, and treating the two as one is how trainers lose clients and, occasionally, more.

PHOTO AND STORY CONSENT

I, _____, give permission for _____ (trainer)
to use the following, for marketing purposes only:

[ ] Before/after photographs, face visible
[ ] Before/after photographs, face not visible
[ ] My first name
[ ] My testimonial in my own words (I will approve the final text)
[ ] My measurements or result figures

Limits I am setting: _____
_____

This permission can be withdrawn by message at any time, after which the material will be removed from the trainer's profiles within 7 days.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

Send the exact post to the client before it goes up. It costs one message and it removes the single most common source of client anger in this industry.

6.9 Session log

One line per session, kept in a notebook, a sheet or a notes app. It takes twenty seconds and it is the difference between 'I think we did squats' and evidence.

Field	Example
Date and session number	14 Nov 2026, session 6 of 24
Attendance	On time / 10 min late / missed
Main work	Goblet squat 3x10 @ 12 kg; row 3x12; plank 3x30s
Progression	Squat +2 kg from last week
Client reported	Knee felt fine; slept 5 hrs; travel Wed-Fri
Action	Reduce Friday volume; send travel plan
Next session	18 Nov, 7 am

The log does three jobs at once. It makes progression deliberate rather than remembered, it gives you the material for the day-30 and day-60 conversations without scrambling, and if a client ever claims they were injured because you were careless, it is the record that shows exactly what was prescribed and what was reported.

End of Part 6 — what to do now

The paperwork takes one afternoon and then protects you for years. Do not skip the health screen because a client looks healthy.

☐ Adapt all eight documents with your name, city and prices. Print ten copies of each form.
☐ Read the health screen and the consent out loud to your next new client at signing.
☐ Get a local advocate to review the agreement once, if your annual revenue is above a few lakh.

PART 1

GST, TDS and income tax

The three tax questions every independent trainer asks, answered with current numbers.

1

This part covers the rules as they stood in October 2026. Tax rules change, sometimes with a few weeks' notice, and your own situation may have facts this chapter does not know about. Use this to understand the landscape and to ask your CA the right questions — not as a substitute for them.

7.1 GST: 5%, and it changed recently

This is the single most misunderstood number in Indian fitness, and most trainers are still working from the old rule. From 22 September 2025, gym, health club, fitness centre, personal training and commercial yoga services are taxed at **5% GST without input tax credit**, down from 18% with ITC. The change came from the 56th GST Council meeting and CBIC has clarified that the 5% rate is mandatory — a gym cannot choose to charge 18% in order to keep claiming credit.

Supply	Rate from 22 Sep 2025	ITC	Code
Gym / fitness centre membership	5%	No	SAC 999723
Personal training sessions	5%	No	SAC 999723
Group classes, aerobics, Zumba, CrossFit	5%	No	SAC 999723
Commercial yoga classes	5%	No	SAC 999723
Gym equipment you buy (treadmill, weights, bands)	18%	As a buyer, yes	HSN 9506
Sports coaching by a charitable entity (12A/12AB)	Exempt	—	—

Do you actually need to register?

GST registration is required once aggregate turnover crosses ₹20 lakh in a financial year, or ₹10 lakh in the notified special-category states (Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland and Tripura). Below that, an independent trainer need not register and need not charge GST. Two practical consequences follow.

1. **Most independent trainers are below the threshold.** At ₹900 a session and 25 sessions a week you are grossing about ₹11.7 lakh a year — comfortably under ₹20 lakh. You should still know the number and check it every quarter, because the threshold counts *aggregate* turnover, including group sessions, online coaching and any product sales.
2. **Once registered, the 5% has no credit.** You cannot set off the GST you paid on equipment, rent or your phone against the GST you collect. That 18% on a treadmill becomes a permanent cost, which is worth remembering before you buy equipment in a registered year.

If you are registered, your invoice needs: your GSTIN, the client's name (and GSTIN if they are a business), a serial number and date, the description of service with SAC 999723, the taxable value, the 5% split as 2.5% CGST + 2.5% SGST within your state (or 5% IGST across states), and the total. If you are not registered, issue a plain receipt as in 6.6 and do not put 'GST' on it.

The gym revenue-share case

If you train the gym's clients on a revenue share, the gym usually invoices the client for the full package and pays you your share. In that case the GST on the client-facing fee is the gym's problem, not yours. But your own invoice to the gym — if you are registered — carries 5%, and the gym cannot claim credit on it. Get this arrangement in writing, because it changes both your tax position and your negotiating position.

7.2 TDS: what gets deducted from you, and what you must deduct

TDS is not an extra tax — it is tax paid early, and it shows up in your Form 26AS and AIS. But it affects your cash flow, and trainers who do not expect it are always surprised in month one.

Section	When it applies to a trainer	Threshold	Rate
194J	A gym, company or clinic pays you professional or technical fees as a non-employee	₹50,000 in a financial year	10% (2% for technical services)
194C	You are engaged as a contractor for a defined piece of work rather than a professional service	₹30,000 single payment or ₹1,00,000 in a year	1% for individual/HUF payee, 2% for others
194M	An individual or HUF pays you for work outside 194C/194H/194J	₹50 lakh in a year	2%

Two things follow. First, expect roughly 10% less than the invoice value when a company or a large gym pays you under 194J — plan for it rather than discovering it. Second, if you pay a physio, a nutritionist, a videographer or a junior trainer for their services, and you are an individual or HUF, you generally do not have to deduct TDS under 194C, 194H or 194J where your own turnover from business or profession is within ₹1 crore (business) or ₹50 lakh (profession) in the preceding year — but confirm this with your CA before relying on it, because the exemption has conditions.

Check your Form 26AS and AIS before filing. Every deduction taken from you should appear there; if a gym deducted 10% and did not deposit it, that is your money stuck, and the sooner you chase it the better your chance of getting it.

7.3 Income tax: which presumptive scheme is yours

Most independent trainers should not be keeping full books. The presumptive scheme exists exactly for this, and the choice between the two versions matters more than most trainers realise — because the one everybody recommends is often the wrong one for a trainer.

	Section 44AD (business)	Section 44ADA (profession)
Who it is for	Eligible business income	Specified professions only
Specified professions	—	Legal, medical, engineering, architecture, accountancy, technical consultancy, interior decoration, plus CBDT-notified: IT, company secretary, film artist, authorised representative
Is fitness training included?	Yes, generally treated as business	Not in the specified list — so generally no
Income declared	8% of turnover, or 6% for receipts through banking/UPI	50% of gross receipts
Turnover ceiling	₹2 crore, or ₹3 crore if cash receipts are 5% or less	₹50 lakh, or ₹75 lakh if cash receipts are 5% or less

The practical point: fitness training is not one of the professions listed for 44ADA, so declaring 50% of receipts under it is usually not open to a personal trainer. Under 44AD you declare 6% of digital receipts, which is dramatically lower — and since almost every trainer's money arrives by UPI or bank transfer, the 6% rate applies to nearly all of it. On ₹12 lakh of receipts that is ₹72,000 of presumptive income instead of ₹6 lakh.

Two caveats, and they are real. First, 44AD requires you to declare at least the presumptive percentage; if your actual profit is higher you may declare more, and if you declare less than the presumptive figure you must keep books and get audited. Second, the five-year lock-in in 44AD means that if you opt out you cannot come back for five years — so the decision is not annual in the same way it is for professionals. Take both points to a CA before you file.

The Income-tax Act, 2025 — what changed on 1 April 2026

Income earned from 1 April 2026 is taxed under the Income-tax Act, 2025, which replaced the 1961 Act and renumbered almost everything. The rates and limits did not change; the section numbers did. The new regime is section 202 (formerly 115BAC), the ₹60,000 rebate is section 156 (formerly 87A), and the TDS provisions sit around section 393 (formerly 194J, 194C and 194-O). When you read a blog post or a CA's note, check whether it is using old or new numbering — and ask your CA for the new section number of the presumptive scheme before you quote it to anyone.

The slabs you will be taxed on (tax year 2026-27, new regime, the default)

Taxable income	Rate	Tax at the top of the band
Up to ₹4,00,000	Nil	₹0
₹4,00,001 - ₹8,00,000	5%	₹20,000
₹8,00,001 - ₹12,00,000	10%	₹60,000
₹12,00,001 - ₹16,00,000	15%	₹1,20,000
₹16,00,001 - ₹20,00,000	20%	₹2,00,000
₹20,00,001 - ₹24,00,000	25%	₹3,00,000
Above ₹24,00,000	30%	₹3,00,000 + 30% of the excess

A resident individual with taxable income up to ₹12 lakh gets a rebate of up to ₹60,000 under section 156, which wipes out the tax entirely — so ₹12 lakh of taxable income means zero tax. Health and education cess of 4% applies on top of whatever tax is payable, and there is no separate senior-citizen slab in the new regime.

A worked example

Priya trains 22 clients a week in Pune and grosses ₹11,50,000 in tax year 2026-27, of which ₹11,20,000 arrives by UPI and ₹30,000 in cash. She uses the presumptive scheme under 44AD and declares 6% of her digital receipts and 8% of her cash receipts: ₹67,200 + ₹2,400 = ₹69,600 of presumptive income. That is below ₹4 lakh, so her tax is nil. Even at a much larger ₹20 lakh of turnover, presumptive income would be about ₹1.2 lakh — still nil tax under the new regime, though she would be at the GST threshold and need to think about registration.

That is the real reason the presumptive route matters for trainers: at typical independent-trainer revenues, it is the difference between filing a simple return with no tax and paying an accountant to reconstruct a year of expenses. Note the honest limit, though — the scheme declares a percentage, not your actual profit, so it is a legal simplification and not a way to hide income. If your real profit is far above the presumptive figure, declaring the minimum is lawful but you should know that you are doing it.

7.4 Records and the monthly twenty minutes

You do not need accounting software. You need four records, kept monthly, that let you file without panic and answer a notice if one ever comes.

- ☐ A payment register: date, client, amount, mode, receipt number. One sheet, one row per payment.
- ☐ Bank and UPI statements, downloaded monthly and kept as PDFs. Do not rely on the app's history.
- ☐ Expense records with receipts: equipment, travel, certification, phone, rent, insurance, software. Photograph every paper receipt the day you get it.
- ☐ Client agreements and receipts, filed per client, kept for at least eight years.
- ☐ A monthly twenty-minute routine: download statements, update the register, photograph receipts, check the running turnover against the ₹20 lakh GST line, file everything in one folder named YYYY-MM.

If a notice arrives

It happens to honest people: a mismatch between your return and the AIS, a TDS entry that never made it to your account, a late fee for a year you thought was nil. The response is always the same and it is always boring. Do not ignore it, because the penalty compounds. Gather the three things that answer almost every query — the payment register, the bank and UPI statements for the year, and the client agreements — and reply within the deadline given. If the amount involved is more than a few thousand rupees, or if the notice mentions a reassessment, hand it to a CA the same week. A CA charges far less for a reply than for a rescue.

The one habit that pays for this book

Put 30% of every payment into a separate account the day it arrives. Not because your tax rate is 30% — because at typical trainer revenues it is close to zero, and the buffer becomes your equipment fund, your certification fund and your quiet-month fund. Trainers who do this survive their first bad February; trainers who do not, quit in it.

End of Part 7 — what to do now

Tax is a filing problem, not a moral one, and it is solved by four records kept monthly. Set the routine now, while there is little to catch up on.

☐ Confirm with a CA whether you are on the presumptive scheme, and which one applies to you.
☐ Open the separate 30% account and move this month's payments into it.
☐ Set a monthly 20-minute reminder: statements, register, receipts, turnover check against ₹20 lakh.

PART 1

AI prompts and the tool stack

What to pay for, what to use free, and eighteen prompts that save hours a week.

1

8.1 The stack, with prices checked in October 2026

You need one paid AI subscription at most, and possibly none. Here is the honest position on price, from India App Store listings checked on 30 October 2026 and from company pricing pages checked in the same week.

Tool	Plan	India price	Do you need it?
ChatGPT	Free	₹0	Start here. Enough for messages, programs and content drafts
ChatGPT	Go	₹399/month	Yes, if you use it daily and hit free limits
ChatGPT	Plus	₹1,999/month	Only if you use documents, images and long analysis weekly
Google Gemini	Free	₹0	Good alternative; strong inside Gmail and Docs
Google AI	Plus	₹399/month	Reasonable budget paid tier, includes 400 GB storage
Google AI	Pro	₹1,950/month	Not necessary for a solo trainer
Claude	Free / Pro	₹0 / ₹1,999/month (App Store)	Good for long writing; Pro only if you write a lot

The rule: one paid subscription, maximum ₹400 a month until your revenue crosses about ₹50,000 a month. A trainer earning ₹40,000 a month who pays ₹1,999 for AI and ₹1,500 for three other apps has spent 9% of income on tools that do not train anyone. The free tiers plus a ₹399 plan will do everything in this chapter.

What AI is genuinely good at for a trainer: drafting messages in your voice, turning a program into a client-friendly one-pager, writing captions and carousels, summarising a week of session notes, drafting policies, and generating practice questions for your own certification study. What it is bad at, and must not be used for: diagnosing pain or injury, prescribing diets for medical conditions, or replacing the judgement you apply when a client walks in looking exhausted.

> **The redaction rule**
> Before you paste anything into an AI tool, remove the client's name, phone number, address, photos and any medical detail. Use 'Client A, 34, desk job, knee pain on stairs (cleared by doctor)'. The tool does not need to know who they are to help you write a message.

8.2 Eighteen prompts

Each prompt is written to be pasted as-is with the brackets filled in. They assume a general-purpose assistant and no special setup.

Programming and delivery

8.1 THE 12-WEEK BLOCK

You are an experienced strength coach in India. Build a 12-week progressive plan for [client profile: age, sex, occupation, training history, days per week, equipment available, session length]. Constraints: [injury or limitation cleared by a doctor / none]. Output: three 4-week blocks, each with exercises, sets, reps, rest, and the progression rule for week to week. Add one sentence per block on what the client should notice changing. Do not include any medical or diagnostic advice.

8.2 THE TRAVEL WEEK

My client trains [days] a week with [equipment]. Next week they are travelling and have a hotel room, no equipment and 20 minutes a day. Give me two 20-minute sessions using bodyweight only, plus one 10-minute mobility routine, written so a beginner can follow them from a phone screen. Flag anything that needs a chair, wall or towel.

8.3 THE BEGINNER'S FIRST MONTH

Write a plain-language one-page guide for a complete beginner starting with me next week in [city]. Cover: what to wear, what to bring, what the first session will feel like, how sore they will be and for how long, what to eat before and after in ordinary Indian food terms, and three things not to do. Keep it under 400 words, friendly, no jargon.

8.4 PROGRESS NOTE FROM SESSION LOGS

Here are my raw session notes for a client over four weeks: [paste notes]. Turn them into a short progress note I can send on WhatsApp: what improved, what stalled, what changes next, and one specific thing to keep doing. Maximum 120 words, warm but factual.

Sales and messages

8.5 THE FIRST REPLY

Rewrite this enquiry reply so it sounds like a busy, honest Indian personal trainer, not a salesperson. Keep it under 70 words, ask at most two questions, never quote a price before the consultation: [paste your draft].

8.6 OBJECTION RESPONSES

A client says: '[objection: too expensive / no time / need to think / will start next month / tried before and it did not work]'. Give me three replies in different registers: warm, direct, and value-first. Each under 60 words, no discounts, no pressure, no exclamation marks.

8.7 THE RENEWAL MESSAGE

Write a renewal message for a client finishing a 12-week block. Facts: [what they achieved], [next goal], [three package options and prices]. Tone: matter-of-fact, no hype, no 'journey'. Under 130 words, ending with a question that asks them to choose an option.

8.8 THE DIFFICULT CONVERSATION
I need to tell a client that [their sessions are unpaid / they keep cancelling late / they are not following the plan / I am raising my rate]. Give me a 100-word message that is direct without being cold, states the fact once, offers one solution, and does not apologise more than once.

Content

8.9 THE TWELVE-POST PLAN
Create a 12-post Instagram plan for an Indian personal trainer in [city] whose clients are [audience]. Use this mix: transformation, process, cue video, client quote, myth, day in the life, beginner guide, local, offer, objection, behind the plan, ask. For each: the hook line, the caption in under 80 words, and the visual in one sentence. No motivational quotes.

8.10 REEL SCRIPTS
Write five 30-second reel scripts for a trainer. Each: hook in the first 3 seconds, one exercise demonstration, one cue, one common mistake, one line on who it is for. Written as spoken lines, not prose. Indian English, no jargon.

8.11 THE LOCAL CAPTION
Write three captions for a photo of a client training in [park/society] in [locality, city]. Each should mention the locality naturally, describe one specific thing happening in the photo, and end with a soft call to action. Under 60 words each.

8.12 THE CAROUSEL
Turn this into a 6-slide Instagram carousel: [paste your idea]. Slide 1 is a hook under 8 words. Slides 2-5 are one idea each, under 25 words. Slide 6 is the ask. Also give me the caption, under 100 words, and 8 relevant hashtags that are not generic.

Admin and business

8.13 POLICY DRAFTS
Draft a [cancellation / refund / late-arrival / package-expiry] policy for an independent personal trainer in India. Plain English, 6 clauses maximum, fair to both sides, no legal jargon. I will have a local advocate review it before use.

8.14 PRICING SANITY CHECK
Here are my numbers: fixed monthly costs ₹[X], travel per session ₹[Y], sessions per week [Z], current rate ₹[A], target take-home ₹[B]. Work out my cost per session, my break-even sessions, and the rate I need to hit my target. Show the arithmetic and tell me the single biggest lever.

8.15 CLIENT P&L
Here is my client list with package, price, start date and sessions used: [paste]. Tell me revenue per client, revenue per session, which clients are most valuable per hour, and which two I should focus on retaining. Show the maths.

8.16 THE MONTHLY REVIEW

Here are my numbers for [month]: enquiries [X], consultations [Y], sign-ups [Z], renewals [R], revenue ₹[A], sessions delivered [B]. Tell me where the biggest leak is, what to change next month, and one thing to stop doing. Be blunt.

8.17 STUDY FOR YOUR CERTIFICATION

I am preparing for [certification name]. Ask me 10 multiple-choice questions on [topic] at the level of that exam, one at a time, and explain each answer after I respond. Do not move on until I answer.

8.18 THE WEEKLY PLAN FOR YOU

I am a personal trainer working [X] hours a week with [Y] clients. Build me a realistic weekly schedule that protects two hours for marketing, one hour for admin and one full rest day, and show where travel time actually falls. Flag any day that is over 8 hours of contact time.

One habit that makes all eighteen better: keep a single notes file with your best outputs — the messages that worked, the program templates, the captions that got replies. Paste them back in as examples ('write in this voice') and the output stops sounding like a machine and starts sounding like you.

End of Part 8 — what to do now

AI will not coach your clients, but it will take the writing, the drafting and the planning off your evenings. One paid subscription is the limit.

☐ Pick one tool and pay for the cheapest plan that covers your use — ₹0 or ₹399 for most trainers.
☐ Save your six best prompts in a notes file with your own voice as an example.
☐ Apply the redaction rule to every prompt before you paste anything about a client.

PART 1

Worksheets

Five sheets to fill in. Print them, or copy the structure into a notebook.

1

9.1 Pricing worksheet

Fixed monthly costs	
Working days a month	
Fixed cost per working day	
Sessions per working day	
Fixed cost per session	
Travel per session	
Unpaid minutes per session	
Target monthly take-home	
Sessions available per month	
Income needed per session	
Minimum price per session	
With tax and buffer (+15%)	
My current rate	
Gap	

9.2 Capacity and income plan

	Current	Target (90 days)	Target (12 months)
Sessions per week			
Average rate per session			
Gross monthly revenue			
Clients on packages			
Average client stay (weeks)			
Renewal rate			
Referrals per month			
Google reviews			

Fill the current column from memory now, and the 90-day column with numbers you can defend. A target you cannot compute is a wish.

9.3 The twelve-month calendar

Month	Demand	My focus	One number I will move
November	Pre-wedding, corporates planning January	Post proof daily, ask for referrals	
December	Wedding clients, early-bird January sales	Sell January before January	
January	Peak enquiries	Reply fast, consult, convert	
February	Wedding peak	Retention and renewals	
March	Post-wedding dip	Re-engage lapsed clients, raise prices for new clients	
April	Summer prep begins	Online coaching push	
May	Early summer, travel season	Travel-proof programs, small groups	
June	Monsoon lull	Content, certifications, systems	
July	Steady	Referral engine, corporate pitches	
August	Festive run-up, Rakhi	Group offers, society drives	
September	Festive season, Navratri	Festival-week programs, retention	
October	Diwali, pre-wedding starts	Ask for reviews, fill November	

9.4 Retention tracker

One row per client. Tick the box when the touchpoint happens. A client with three unticked boxes is a client about to leave, and you will see it weeks before they go.

Client	Start	Block ends	D7	D14	D30	D45	D60 renewal	D90
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
			☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

9.5 Monthly P&L, in eight lines

Line	This month	Last month	Notes
Sessions delivered			Count them, do not estimate
Revenue received (not invoiced)			Cash in, not promises
Travel cost			Fuel, auto, metro
Equipment and repairs			
Certification and education			
Software and subscriptions			Cancel one this month
Other fixed costs			Rent, phone, insurance
Net before tax			Revenue minus the above
Average per session			Revenue ÷ sessions
Hours worked (all of it)			Include travel and admin
Earnings per hour			The number that tells the truth

The last line is the one to watch for a year. A trainer whose earnings per hour fall while revenue rises is working harder for the same money, and the fix is always the same: fewer sessions, higher rate, less travel.

End of Part 9 — what to do now

Worksheets only work if they are filled in with real numbers. Ten minutes with a pen beats an hour of planning in your head.

☐ Fill in the pricing worksheet and the P&L with last month's actual figures.
☐ Set the twelve-month calendar with one number to move per month.
☐ Print the retention tracker and stick it where you write your programs.

PART 1

Your first 30 days

One page. Print it, stick it where you will see it.

1

The checklist

- ☐ Week 1 — Do the money maths in 2.1 and write down your floor price. Do not skip this.
- ☐ Week 1 — Build three tiers (2.3) and decide which one you will actually sell.
- ☐ Week 1 — Set up or claim your Google Business Profile (3.3). Add ten photos.
- ☐ Week 1 — Write your four payment rules and put them in your agreement (2.6, 6.5).
- ☐ Week 2 — Adapt the intake form, health screen, consent and agreement (Part 6). Print ten copies.
- ☐ Week 2 — Create WhatsApp quick replies from templates 5.1-5.9.
- ☐ Week 2 — Message ten past clients and enquirers (templates 5.13, 5.14).
- ☐ Week 2 — Ask three current clients for a Google review, in person, with the link open.
- ☐ Week 3 — Start the 30-day sprint (3.2) at day 1. Block 45 minutes a day in your calendar.
- ☐ Week 3 — Post three transformations you have permission to use.
- ☐ Week 3 — Pitch two societies and one office (3.7).
- ☐ Week 4 — Put every current client on the retention tracker (9.4) and fill in their dates.
- ☐ Week 4 — Have one day-45 or day-60 conversation this month, using 4.5 or 4.6.
- ☐ Week 4 — Set up the 30% account and move this month's payments into it (7.4).
- ☐ Week 4 — Do the monthly P&L (9.5). Write down your earnings per hour.
- ☐ Every month — One price rise conversation with a new client. One review ask. One referral ask.

If you do only one thing

Put every current client on the retention tracker and send the day-7, day-14 and day-30 messages. It costs two and a half hours a month, requires no marketing budget, and it is the only change in this book that pays you back in the same month you make it.

Sources and verification log

Every figure in this playbook was checked against the following sources in October 2026. Where a source labels something an estimate, this book says so in the text.

Figure used	Source	Checked
₹16,200 crore market, 46,500 facilities, 12.3 million members, 0.8% penetration, ₹37,700 crore and 23.2 million members by 2030, boutique 18.8% CAGR	Deloitte-HFA India Fitness Market Report 2025	Oct 2026
60,000-80,000 independent trainers (estimate), 24,000-26,000 platform-listed, ~80% quit within two years, ~60% drop-off in 90 days, 70-75% monthly retention, ₹500-2,500 metro session rate	Gymbo, State of India's Independent Personal Trainers 2026 (industry data report)	Oct 2026
GST 5% without ITC on fitness services from 22 September 2025, SAC 999723, mandatory per CBIC, ₹20 lakh / ₹10 lakh threshold, equipment HSN 9506 at 18%	CBIC rate notifications as summarised by TaxClue, Taxzentic and TAXAJ (all updated 2026)	Oct 2026
194J threshold ₹50,000 at 10% (2% technical), 194C ₹30,000/₹1,00,000 at 1%/2%, 194M ₹50 lakh	Income Tax Department, threshold limits and small-business benefits pages (AY 2026-27)	Oct 2026
44ADA ₹50 lakh / ₹75 lakh and the specified-profession list; 44AD ₹2 crore / ₹3 crore at 8% / 6%	Income Tax Department presumptive taxation pages; LiveMint ITR explainer, June 2026	Oct 2026
Income-tax Act 2025 live from 1 April 2026; section 202, section 156, section 393 renumbering; slabs and ₹60,000 rebate	Income Tax Department slab pages; Finance Act 2026; EIRC ICAI note, October 2026	Oct 2026
AI subscription prices in India: ChatGPT Go ₹399, Plus ₹1,999, Google AI Pro ₹1,950, Claude Pro ₹1,999 App Store	India App Store listings and company pricing pages, via Kingy and Puley price trackers	30 Oct 2026

Two honest caveats. Rates and thresholds in Indian tax law change, sometimes between the printing of a guide and the reading of it; the GST rate on fitness services changed in September 2025 and could change again, so confirm on the CBIC portal before you invoice. And the trainer-population figures are triangulated estimates, not a census — the segment is partly invisible by nature because so many trainers work entirely through WhatsApp. Everything else here is either a published statistic or arithmetic you can check yourself.

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